

Windows Movie Maker 2

Capturing Video: Which Format?

 Transferring video from a digital camcorder onto your hard drive can be difficult because of huge file sizes. Until recently, video capture was the hardest step for the home video maker as it was fraught with hardware conflicts, system crashes, and dropped frames.

Fortunately, Windows Movie Maker 2 (WMM2) makes the capture process relatively painless. This is due, in part, to Windows XP and its inbuilt support for digital video and picture. On top of that, WMM2's capture wizard is simple, straightforward, and a huge boon for the amateur video maker.

However, before you capture video in WMM2, you need to decide what format you want to capture into? WMM2 lets you capture in both the traditional DV-AVI format, and Windows own WMV format. Each has its own merits.

The DV-AVI Format

 The first format you capture into is DV-AVI. This format, also known as DV or 'digital video', is the video compression format that your camcorder captures onto tape. This format is saved at 30 frames per second. You get video that is potentially of higher quality than a commercial DVD. DV-AVI is the capture and editing format of choice for most video software programs, and they will all recognise it.

However, the digital video format is not without its problems, the major inconvenience being the huge file sizes. Each minute of video takes up a whopping 200 MB of space. That means an hour long tape occupies about 13 GB of hard drive space! If you don't have much hard drive space available you're going to run into problems.

Windows Media Video 9

 WMM2 offers you the ability to capture your video into its own WMV9

format. The Windows Media format is set as the 'recommended' default setting when you first attempt a capture. This video format is great, and saves your video into incredibly high-quality video that takes up a tenth of the space that DV does. The quality of WMV9 is so good that some movie theatre companies are switching to digital projectors, dumping their old fashioned film projectors, and projecting their movies from WMV9 files. The compression level of WMV9 is incredible and allows you to backup and create collections of videos on your computer.

However, the WMV9 format has problems. When first capturing your camcorder movie through a FireWire cable, to save the movie into WMV, your computer has to re-encode the video into the WMV9 format on the fly. Even if you set the compression level to highest quality, you are going to lose some of your video image quality through the encoding process. You always lose image quality when you re-encode a video, no matter how high your settings.

The other problem with the format is that it's Microsoft's proprietary

format, and no other program uses or recognises WMV9. That means you're stuck using WMM2 for editing.

So Which One To Choose?

 If you're going to capture a short section of video from your camcorder, say less than 10 minutes (or if the video quality must be the highest quality), we recommend sticking with the original DV-AVI format. If you are hard-pressed for hard drive space, or must capture a long amount of tape, the WMV9 format is just fine. However, if you do go with WMV9, we recommend not using the recommended setting for capture. Set the capture quality level to the absolute maximum (called 'high quality') as you should always start with the highest quality source video before you begin editing.

Improving Capture Performance In WMM2

 Capturing video onto your hard drive can be frustrating. That's because digital video from your camcorder is very large, and not every system can handle the sustained capture speeds needed to transfer your movie over a FireWire cable onto your hard drive.

Fortunately, most computers today are powerful enough to capture video. For example, you can easily capture and edit video on a 1 GHz-plus laptop computer, and never run into any problems. However, if you do run into problems during capturing, there are several things you can do to speed up your system.

Defragment Your Hard Drives

Defragmenting a drive is an easy performance enhancer, and you should defragment regularly.

Get A Faster Drive

The main hurdle to capturing big video files is the speed of your hard drive. When you stream video onto your computer through a FireWire cable, the digital video is written onto your hard drive as a large DV-AVI file. This stream runs at a constant 200 MB per minute, and if your hard drive slows down while this stream is running, you will lose some of your video and get dropped frames.

To avoid hard drive hiccups, you should close any background programs, and you may need to invest in a faster 7,200 or even 10,000 rpm hard drive.

Use The NTFS Partition

If your drive is partitioned in the older FAT32 format, then this is your most likely culprit for capture problems. The older partition structure isn't optimised for video capture, and won't let you capture video files over a certain size (two or four GB).

Windows Media Codec

If you can't get rid of dropped frames when capturing in the DV-AVI format, you can always try capturing in WMM2's WMV9 codec. Because this format generates small file sizes, you won't run into dropped frames from an underperforming hard drive. However, the compression itself might be tasking on your CPU.

Turn The Preview Monitor Off

When you capture video, you can watch the video capture inside WMM2's preview monitor. However, generating this preview video is tasking

GENERAL TIPS

Windows Movie Maker 2
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Flash MX 2004

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30 MINUTES EXPERT

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